The AI spend control loop

Five steps to keep AI spend growing slower than the value it produces.

+49.5%

Forecast growth in worldwide AI spending in 2026, to $2.7 trillion.

Gartner, Sept 2026

3.2×

Growth in enterprise generative AI spend from 2024 to 2025, from $11.5B to $37B.

Menlo Ventures, Dec 2025

52%

of 700 engineering and FinOps leaders say there is no clear owner for AI cost.

Harness, a FinOps vendor, June 2026

For CFOs, IT and ops leaders, and owners who sign the AI bills

Swipe →

01
Own it

Name one person who owns AI spend, and review it every month like phones or software.

- Give each team its own AI budget, so a jump has an address.
- Count card and expense purchases, not only what IT bought.

> **Working when:** You can say who approved last month’s AI bill within a day.

02
Measure per team and per task

Put a gateway in front of every model call, with one key and one budget per team.

- The open-source LiteLLM proxy logs spend by key, team and user, and stops requests when a budget runs out.
- For seats, pull each tool's admin usage report and remove seats idle for 30 days.

> **Working when:** You can name the workflow behind last month’s increase.

03

Route to the cheapest model that passes

A provider’s most expensive current model costs 20 to 200 times more per token than its cheapest.

- Collect 20 to 50 real examples of each high-volume task, with the answer you expect.
- Test models from smallest to largest and keep the smallest one that passes.

> **Working when:** Every high-volume task has a named model and a test set.

04

Take the discounts you already have

Caching and batching cut the bill without changing the output.

- Cache long, repeated instructions: on the newest Anthropic, OpenAI and Google models, cached input costs a tenth of the normal price or less.
- Batch work that can wait a day: Anthropic, OpenAI and Google all take 50% off.

> **Working when:** Repeated prompts hit the cache, and overnight jobs run as batches.

05

Train everyone on the cheap way

Every user picks a model, a prompt length and how long a thread runs, and each choice moves the bill.

- Teach when the small model is enough, and when to start a fresh thread instead of resending a long one.
- Publish a one-page policy: approved tools, what never goes in, and who checks output.

> **Working when:** Cost per task falls while usage rises.

Track every month

- Cost per completed task, by workflow
- Seats idle for 30 days
- Share of calls that go to the top model
- Cache hit rate on repeated prompts
- Number of surprise bills

Take the whole framework

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Copy it, plus free agent skills

github.com/steeltownai/toolkit

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